Autopilot Off: Why Am I Here?

Read-aloud script · about 60 minutes · read from the top

How to use this script. Say the Part titles out loud, so the room always knows where you are. The point titles are there to help you find your place. Anything in [square brackets] is a cue for you, so don't read it out. Everything else is written to be said just as it appears.

The session at a glance

- **Opening:** Bismillah, a dua, and a warm-up game
- **Part 1, The Problem:** living on autopilot
- **Part 2, The Question:** only humans ask "why?"
- **Part 3, The Proof:** nothing is accidental
- **Part 4, The Answer:** four reasons you are here
- **Part 5, Your Part:** finding your own role
- **Part 6, Staying Power:** courage, company and fuel
- **Part 7, The Plan:** your first week and beyond
- **Closing:** the day everyone wakes up

Opening

Bismillah and dua

Bismillah. Before I start, I want to make a dua, the same dua Musa, alayhis-salam, made before he went to face Pharaoh. It's in Surah Ta-Ha, verses 25 to 28:

> رَبِّ اشْرَحْ لِي صَدْرِي ۝ وَيَسِّرْ لِي أَمْرِي ۝ وَاحْلُلْ عُقْدَةً مِّن لِّسَانِي ۝ يَفْقَهُوا قَوْلِي

"My Lord, open up my chest, make my task easy for me, and untie the knot from my tongue so that they understand my words."

Assalamu alaykum wa rahmatullahi wa barakatuh, everyone. Alhamdulillah, and peace and blessings on the Messenger of Allah صلى الله عليه وسلم.

A quick game

Before I say anything serious, let's start with a quick game. Turn to the person next to you.

You've got thirty seconds. Tell them what you did in the first hour after you woke up today, in order. Go.

[Give them thirty seconds.]

Okay, that's time. Hands up if the first thing you touched this morning was your phone. Keep your hand up if you were scrolling before you'd done anything else. Yeah. Me too, on a bad day.

Now here's a harder question, and you don't have to answer it out loud. Not what did you do today, but why? Why did you get up? Why are you on the course, or in the job, or in the friend group you're in? Was that really your decision, or did it just… happen?

What this hour is about

This session is called Autopilot Off. By the end of the hour, I promise you three things. First, a clear answer to the question "Why am I here?" Second, a method for finding your own specific role in this world. And third, a seven-day plan you can start tomorrow.

Here's how we'll get there. Part one is the problem: how we end up living on autopilot. Part two is the question: why only humans ask "why?" Part three is the proof that nothing around us is accidental. Part four is the answer: four reasons you are here. Part five is about finding your own role. Part six is what keeps you going. And part seven is your plan for the first week. Okay. Let's begin.

Part 1: The Problem — Living on Autopilot

Point 1: The NPC and the zombie

First, the problem. If you game, you know what an NPC is: a non-player character. It walks the same loop, says the same line, and has no idea there's a bigger game going on around it.

And be honest with me: how many of us live like that? Wake up. Go to school, or uni, or work. Scroll. Eat. Scroll. Sleep. Repeat. And when somebody asks, "What's it all for?", we shrug and say, "That's just life," or, "I'm just going with the flow."

The lecture I'm drawing from today calls this living like zombies. That means living on autopilot, with no sense of what I'm working towards, what my mission is, or where I'm going.

Point 2: The sheep and the crowd

The second problem is that we don't just do it, we do it together, like sheep. We follow the

crowd, because nobody wants to stick out like a sore thumb.

Let me show you how strong that pull is. Everyone, on three, I want you to look up at the ceiling and keep looking. Don't ask why. One, two, three. Keep looking. Keep looking.

[Hold it for a few seconds.]

Okay, you can come back down.

Nobody told you why. There was nothing up there. You did it because I asked, and because everyone else was doing it.

And there's a famous experiment that shows exactly this. In 1969, a psychologist called Stanley Milgram and his team stood a few people on a busy New York pavement, all staring up at an empty window. The bigger the group that stared, the more passers-by stopped and stared too. Nobody gave them a reason. We're wired to follow the crowd. That's not evil, it's human. But if the crowd is walking towards a cliff, "everyone was doing it" isn't going to save you.

The Qur'an describes exactly this habit. Allah says, in Surah az-Zukhruf, verse 22:

> بَلْ قَالُوا إِنَّا وَجَدْنَا آبَاءَنَا عَلَىٰ أُمَّةٍ وَإِنَّا عَلَىٰ آثَارِهِم مُّهْتَدُونَ

"Rather, they say: 'We found our fathers following a way, and we are guided in their footsteps.'"

Now, I know some of you are thinking about your parents right now, so let me be clear. The problem is not honouring our parents, and it's not following good guidance. Our parents have sacrificed so much for us, and Islam tells us to be good to them. The problem is following without thinking. Following just because "that's what people do."

Allah also describes people who have eyes, ears and hearts, but don't use them to see the truth. He says in Surah al-A'raf, verse 179:

> لَهُمْ قُلُوبٌ لَّا يَفْقَهُونَ بِهَا وَلَهُمْ أَعْيُنٌ لَّا يُبْصِرُونَ بِهَا وَلَهُمْ آذَانٌ لَّا يَسْمَعُونَ بِهَا ۚ أُولَٰئِكَ كَالْأَنْعَامِ بَلْ هُمْ أَضَلُّ

"They have hearts with which they do not understand, eyes with which they do not see, and ears with which they do not hear. They are like cattle. No, they are even more astray."

Please hear that as a mirror, not as a stick. It's not there for us to point at other people. It's a question for me: am I using my heart, my eyes and my ears, or am I just moving with the herd?

And for the moments when you're the one who doesn't look up with everyone else, the Prophet صلى الله عليه وسلم gave us comfort. He said: "Islam began as something strange, and it will return to being strange, so glad tidings to the strangers." This is in Sahih Muslim. It's okay to look in a different direction, as long as that direction is the truth.

Point 3: When autopilot stops working

Let me tell you about a man who had everything. A famous author, Leo Tolstoy, who wrote War and Peace and Anna Karenina. Best-selling books, wealth, fame, a family, an estate. And around the age of fifty, he wrote that none of it was holding him up any more. He kept asking: Why am I here? Where is all of this going? What is the point of what I do today, or of my whole life, if it all ends?

We can call that a crisis of meaning. Viktor Frankl, the psychiatrist who survived the Nazi camps, wrote about what he called an "existential vacuum". That's a deep inner emptiness that shows up when life has no "why". And he argued that a person can bear almost any "how" if they have a "why".

Now, one honest note. Depression and anxiety have many causes, biological, social and personal, and they often need proper professional care, which Islam encourages. The Prophet صلى الله عليه وسلم said: "Seek treatment, servants of Allah, for Allah has not placed a disease except that He placed a cure for it." This is in Sunan Abi Dawud. So I'm not saying a missing purpose is the only cause of anything. I'm saying a missing "why" is a heavy weight that a lot of young people carry quietly, and it deserves to be taken seriously.

Philosophy even has a name for "nothing matters". It's called nihilism. You can try to build a whole life on it. But notice how the heart refuses to live there for long.

So where do we go from here? We start with the one thing animals don't do.

Part 2: The Question — Only Humans Ask "Why?"

Point 1: What makes us different from animals?

I want you to shout out some answers. What's the difference between a human being and an animal? Go on, call them out.

[Take a few answers from the room.]

Good answers, all of them. Now let's test them. Animals communicate. Crows solve puzzles: they'll bend a wire into a hook to get food. Elephants appear to mourn their dead. Animals protect their young, compete, fight, and choose their mates. So it isn't simply intelligence, and it isn't simply emotion.

But everyone in this room still knows there's something fundamentally different. Here's one way to see it. Animals eat, drink, survive, reproduce and compete. But as far as anyone has ever observed, they never stop and ask why. There are no animal universities. No animal libraries. No animal places of worship. And no animal lies awake at two in the morning wondering what its life is for.

Only we do that.

Point 2: Where the question comes from

And Allah tells us where it comes from. He says in Surah an-Nahl, verse 78:

> وَاللَّهُ أَخْرَجَكُم مِّن بُطُونِ أُمَّهَاتِكُمْ لَا تَعْلَمُونَ شَيْئًا وَجَعَلَ لَكُمُ السَّمْعَ وَالْأَبْصَارَ وَالْأَفْئِدَةَ ۙ لَعَلَّكُمْ تَشْكُرُونَ

“Allah brought you out of your mothers’ wombs knowing nothing, and gave you hearing, sight and hearts, so that you may be grateful.”

And in Surah al-Isra, verse 70:

> وَلَقَدْ كَرَّمْنَا بَنِي آدَمَ

“We have certainly honoured the children of Adam.”

That restless question in your chest, “Why am I here?”, is not a malfunction. It’s a feature. It’s the thing Allah gave human beings that He didn’t give anyone else: the ability, and the desire, to ask why.

And even we don’t fully understand what makes us us. Allah says to the Prophet صلى الله عليه وسلم, in Surah al-Isra, verse 85:

> وَيَسْأَلُونَكَ عَنِ الرُّوحِ ۖ قُلِ الرُّوحُ مِنْ أَمْرِ رَبِّي وَمَا أُوتِيتُم مِّنَ الْعِلْمِ إِلَّا قَلِيلًا

“They ask you about the soul. Say: the soul is from the affair of my Lord, and you have been given only a little knowledge.”

The soul is from the command of Allah, from the matters only He fully knows, and we’ve only been given a little knowledge of it. Animals are conscious, yes. But do they think about their own existence? Do they ask what ideas are for? Do they yearn and search for meaning and purpose? That’s a gift, it’s a mystery, and it’s built into you.

Point 3: Asking questions doesn’t mean weak faith

Now, some of you worry that asking questions means your faith is weak. Look at Ibrahim, alayhis-salam. As a young man, he watched the star, the moon and the sun rise and set, and he reasoned his way, out loud, to the truth. And he said, in Surah al-An‘am, verse 79:

> إِنِّي وَجَّهْتُ وَجْهِيَ لِلَّذِي فَطَرَ السَّمَاوَاتِ وَالْأَرْضَ حَنِيفًا ۖ وَمَا أَنَا مِنَ الْمُشْرِكِينَ

“Indeed, I have turned my face to the One who created the heavens and the earth, inclining to the truth, and I am not of those who associate others with Allah.”

So ask your questions. Ask sincerely, to find the truth, not to run away from responsibility. And ask people who can actually answer them.

Part 3: The Proof — Nothing Is Accidental

Point 1: Design points to purpose

Now, how do we know there's a purpose behind all this? Allah asks us to look at the world around us and reach exactly that conclusion: that it could not have been created without a purpose. Every single thing around us has one. Listen to how He describes the people who think deeply about it. He says, in Surah Ali 'Imran, verse 191:

> الَّذِينَ يَذْكُرُونَ اللَّهَ قِيَامًا وَقُعُودًا وَعَلَىٰ جُنُوبِهِمْ وَيَتَفَكَّرُونَ فِي خَلْقِ السَّمَاوَاتِ وَالْأَرْضِ رَبَّنَا مَا خَلَقْتَ هَٰذَا بَاطِلًا سُبْحَانَكَ فَقِنَا عَذَابَ النَّارِ

"Those who remember Allah standing, sitting, and lying on their sides, and reflect on the creation of the heavens and the earth: 'Our Lord, You did not create this in vain. Glory be to You. Protect us from the punishment of the Fire.'"

So Allah describes people who think of Him standing, sitting and on their sides, and who think deeply about how this whole universe was created. And they reach a conclusion: "Our Lord, You must have made all of this for a purpose."

Here's the logic. Pick up a door handle. You can tell it was made to be pushed or pulled. A spoon is shaped to hold something. You don't need a manual, because the shape tells you the purpose. Where you see deliberate design, you see intention.

If your little cousin scribbles on a page and proudly shows you, you say, "MashaAllah, beautiful!" But you both know there was no plan behind it. Now imagine I told you that in a desert, the sun melted the sand into silicon, the wind blew it together, and after a few hundred years out came an iPhone. You'd laugh. Yet the human eye, with its lens, its retina, and a brain to decode what it sees, is far more sophisticated than any phone.

Point 2: Science answers "how", not "why"

Now, some of you study biology. You've met natural selection in your textbooks: the idea that living things adapt to their environment over time, like birds' beaks changing. I'm not here to fight your science teacher. Adaptation is real and observable, and Allah's creation does adapt.

But notice what science, by its own design, answers. It answers how things change. It doesn't answer, and it can't, why there is anything at all, why it follows such precise laws, or what it's for. "How" and "why" are different questions. When someone takes a "how" and announces "so there's no why", that isn't a lab result. That's a philosophical jump, and you're allowed to notice the jump.

Point 3: The signs Allah points to

And Allah doesn't just tell us this. He challenges us to look, and to ask: why this way, and not another way? Let me show you some of the signs He points to.

Look at the seas. Allah says, in Surah ar-Rahman, verses 19 and 20:

> مَرَجَ الْبَحْرَيْنِ يَلْتَقِيَانِ ۝ بَيْنَهُمَا بَرْزَخٌ لَّا يَبْغِيَانِ

"He released the two seas, meeting side by side. Between them is a barrier they do not cross."

The seas meet and mix, but they don't simply dissolve into one another. Waters of different kinds touch, and each keeps its own character. You have to ask: why this way? Why not the other way?

Look at the sky. Allah says, in Surah Qaf, verse 6:

> أَفَلَمْ يَنظُرُوا إِلَى السَّمَاءِ فَوْقَهُمْ كَيْفَ بَنَيْنَاهَا وَزَيَّنَّاهَا وَمَا لَهَا مِن فُرُوجٍ

"Do they not look at the sky above them: how We built it and adorned it, and it has no cracks?"

Why doesn't the sky collapse on us? Allah says in Surah al-Hajj, verse 65:

> وَيُمْسِكُ السَّمَاءَ أَن تَقَعَ عَلَى الْأَرْضِ إِلَّا بِإِذْنِهِ

"He holds the sky back from falling on the earth, except by His permission."

So look up, and ask yourself: how was it made, and why is it the way it is?

Look at the birds. Allah says, in Surah al-Mulk, verse 19:

> أَوَلَمْ يَرَوْا إِلَى الطَّيْرِ فَوْقَهُمْ صَافَّاتٍ وَيَقْبِضْنَ ۚ مَا يُمْسِكُهُنَّ إِلَّا الرَّحْمَٰنُ

"Do they not see the birds above them, wings spread and folded? None holds them up except the Most Merciful."

Why is a bird able to glide? Human beings spent years studying and copying bird wings to build wings that fly. The Wright brothers studied how birds fly before they built a plane that could. And think about it: if I jump off this stage and flap my arms, nothing is going to happen except a very bad chin. So why did Allah design the bird this way, and not any other way?

Look at the bee. Allah says, in Surah an-Nahl, verses 68 and 69:

> وَأَوْحَىٰ رَبُّكَ إِلَى النَّحْلِ ... يَخْرُجُ مِن بُطُونِهَا شَرَابٌ مُّخْتَلِفٌ أَلْوَانُهُ فِيهِ شِفَاءٌ لِّلنَّاسِ

"Your Lord inspired the bee... from its belly comes a drink of varying colours, in which there is healing for people."

Honey comes out of the bee. Why that way? It was made differently, for a reason.

Look at the ships. Allah says, in Surah ash-Shura, verses 32 and 33:

> وَمِنْ آيَاتِهِ الْجَوَارِ فِي الْبَحْرِ كَالْأَعْلَامِ ۝ إِن يَشَأْ يُسْكِنِ الرِّيحَ فَيَظْلَلْنَ رَوَاكِدَ عَلَىٰ ظَهْرِهِ

"Among His signs are the ships on the sea like mountains. If He willed, He could still the wind, and they would lie motionless on its surface."

Think about what that would mean. If ships couldn't sail, trade would stop. The meal you ate today, the phone in your hand, the clothes you're wearing: most of what we own reached us across the sea. And why does a steel hull float at all? There's a force pushing up from underneath. It could have been otherwise. It was designed this way, on purpose.

Point 4: Try it yourself

Now I want you to try this. Turn to the person next to you. Pick any object in this room. For the next sixty seconds, take turns asking each other questions like a three-year-old would. Why is it this shape? Why not another? Why does it work? Go.

[Give them sixty seconds.]

Okay, I could hear some great ones there. And that sense of wonder isn't childish. It's exactly what Allah asks of us. He says in Surah al-Ghashiyah, verses 17 to 20:

> أَفَلَا يَنظُرُونَ إِلَى الْإِبِلِ كَيْفَ خُلِقَتْ ۝ وَإِلَى السَّمَاءِ كَيْفَ رُفِعَتْ ۝ وَإِلَى الْجِبَالِ كَيْفَ نُصِبَتْ ۝ وَإِلَى الْأَرْضِ كَيْفَ سُطِحَتْ

"Do they not look at the camels, how they were created? At the sky, how it was raised? At the mountains, how they were set up? At the earth, how it was spread out?"

And He asks us the question directly, in Surah al-Mu'minun, verse 115:

> أَفَحَسِبْتُمْ أَنَّمَا خَلَقْنَاكُمْ عَبَثًا وَأَنَّكُمْ إِلَيْنَا لَا تُرْجَعُونَ

"Did you think that We created you for no purpose, and that you would not be returned to Us?"

One of the sad effects of modern life is how disconnected we've become from all of this. We're indoors, behind a screen, and we walk past the signs without seeing them. The fix is simple: step outside and look.

But the main point is this. If nothing around us is accidental, then neither are you. So the real question is: what are we here for?

Part 4: The Answer — Four Reasons You Are Here

The Qur'an and the Sunnah give us four big answers to "Why am I here?" I want you to hold up four fingers, and we'll fold one down for each reason.

Reason 1: To be tested

The first reason is that Allah created us to test us. He says, in Surah al-Mulk, verse 2:

> الَّذِي خَلَقَ الْمَوْتَ وَالْحَيَاةَ لِيَبْلُوَكُمْ أَيُّكُمْ أَحْسَنُ عَمَلًا

"He who created death and life to test you: which of you is best in deed."

Notice the wording. Best in deed, not most deeds. Al-Fudayl ibn 'Iyad, one of the early scholars, explained "best" as the most sincere and the most correct: done purely for Allah, and in line with the Sunnah, the way of the Prophet صلى الله عليه وسلم. It's about quality, not quantity.

So what exactly is being tested? Almost everything. Your results. Your family situation. Your money. Your free time. Your phone. Your friend group. Your temptations. Your talents. Even the economy, the wars and the opportunities around us are all part of the exam paper. Allah says in Surah al-'Ankabut, verse 2:

> أَحَسِبَ النَّاسُ أَن يُتْرَكُوا أَن يَقُولُوا آمَنَّا وَهُمْ لَا يُفْتَنُونَ

"Do people think they will be left to say, 'We believe,' and not be tested?"

And nobody gets exempted for being young. The Prophet صلى الله عليه وسلم said that on the Day of Resurrection, a person's feet will not move until he is asked about five things. Among them: his life, and how he spent it, and his youth, and how he wore it out. This is reported by al-Tirmidhi. Your youth is a specific question on the paper.

Now, that sounds heavy. But a test isn't a trap. Allah gave us the syllabus, the tools, and a huge amount of mercy. So fold one finger down.

Reason 2: To worship

The second reason is worship. Allah says, in Surah adh-Dhariyat, verse 56:

> وَمَا خَلَقْتُ الْجِنَّ وَالْإِنسَ إِلَّا لِيَعْبُدُونِ

"I did not create jinn and mankind except to worship Me."

When you hear the word "worship", you probably picture a prayer mat. And salah is the heart of it. But the Qur'an stretches the word much wider. Allah says in Surah al-An'am, verse 162:

> قُلْ إِنَّ صَلَاتِي وَنُسُكِي وَمَحْيَايَ وَمَمَاتِي لِلَّهِ رَبِّ الْعَالَمِينَ

"Say: my prayer, my sacrifice, my living and my dying are all for Allah, Lord of the worlds."

Ibn Taymiyyah defined worship as an umbrella word for everything Allah loves and is pleased with, in words and in actions, hidden and open. So studying with the intention to serve is worship. Being patient with your mum. Doing an honest day's work. Sleeping early so you can wake for Fajr. Walking out of a group chat that's backbiting someone, which means talking about them behind their back. That's all worship, because the Prophet صلى الله عليه وسلم said: "Deeds are only by intentions." This is in Sahih al-Bukhari and Sahih Muslim.

And worship isn't only a duty. It's a need. Plenty of things bring us joy: friends, success, travel, food. But there's a hunger in the heart that none of them can fully fill. Allah says, in Surah ar-Ra'd, verse 28:

> أَلَا بِذِكْرِ اللَّهِ تَطْمَئِنُّ الْقُلُوبُ

"Truly, in the remembrance of Allah do hearts find rest."

And He gives the other side of the same truth, in Surah Ta-Ha, verse 124:

> وَمَنْ أَعْرَضَ عَن ذِكْرِي فَإِنَّ لَهُ مَعِيشَةً ضَنكًا

"Whoever turns away from My remembrance, indeed, for him is a constricted life."

If we turn away from the very thing we were made for, something inside us stays unsettled, even when everything looks fine from the outside. If you don't fulfil your purpose, you will feel it. So worship. Fold down a second finger.

Reason 3: To be Allah's khalifah and build

The third reason is that Allah made us His khalifah on this earth, and He wants us to build. He says in Surah al-Baqarah, verse 30:

> إِنِّي جَاعِلٌ فِي الْأَرْضِ خَلِيفَةً

"Indeed, I am placing on the earth a khalifah."

Now, khalifah has two meanings. One is a successor, someone who takes over from somebody else. If I'm finished with this mic and I hand it to someone else, they're my khalifah, they've succeeded me. The other meaning is someone who's put in charge of something specific. It's like me saying to someone, "Listen, there's a task I want you to do. You're responsible for it. I'm not going to tell you exactly how to do every part of it, but it's yours." That's what Allah did with us. Not animals, not birds, not bacteria, not jinn. He made us the representatives, the caretakers of this earth. And there are two big jobs.

Job one: uphold truth and goodness, together. Allah says in Surah Ali 'Imran, verse 110:

> كُنتُمْ خَيْرَ أُمَّةٍ أُخْرِجَتْ لِلنَّاسِ تَأْمُرُونَ بِالْمَعْرُوفِ وَتَنْهَوْنَ عَنِ الْمُنكَرِ وَتُؤْمِنُونَ بِاللَّهِ

"You are the best community brought out for mankind: you enjoin what is right, forbid what

is wrong, and believe in Allah.”

And in Surah ash-Shura, verse 13, He tells us to establish the religion, and not to be divided about it:

> أَنْ أَقِيمُوا الدِّينَ وَلَا تَتَفَرَّقُوا فِيهِ

“Establish the religion, and do not be divided about it.”

In plain words: live by what Allah taught, help others towards good, and don’t tear each other apart while you do it. And invite people with wisdom and beautiful speech, not arguments. The Prophet صلى الله عليه وسلم said: “I was only sent to perfect good character.” This is reported by Imam Ahmad. For most of you, your best da‘wah, your best way of inviting people to good, is simply how you treat people.

Job two: build this earth, for good. Allah says in Surah Hud, verse 61:

> هُوَ أَنشَأَكُم مِّنَ الْأَرْضِ وَاسْتَعْمَرَكُمْ فِيهَا

“He brought you into being from the earth and made you settle and build in it.”

Allah wants farms, hospitals, schools, technology, institutions. He wants civilisation. But what kind of building? The Qur’an shows us the wrong kind. In Surah Ghafir, verses 36 and 37, Pharaoh says to his minister Haman:

> وَقَالَ فِرْعَوْنُ يَا هَامَانُ ابْنِ لِي صَرْحًا لَّعَلِّي أَبْلُغُ الْأَسْبَابَ ۝ أَسْبَابَ السَّمَاوَاتِ فَأَطَّلِعَ إِلَىٰ إِلَٰهِ مُوسَىٰ وَإِنِّي لَأَظُنُّهُ كَاذِبًا

“Build me a tower, so that I can reach the ways into the heavens and look at the God of Musa. And I truly think he is a liar.”

A brilliant builder, building out of arrogance. And Allah tells us in Surah ar-Rum, verse 9, that earlier nations dug the earth and built on it even more than we have:

> وَأَثَارُوا الْأَرْضَ وَعَمَرُوهَا أَكْثَرَ مِمَّا عَمَرُوهَا

“They dug up the earth and built on it more than these people have.”

And they were still destroyed, because of how they used their power.

Here’s the modern version of that. In 1816, an eighteen-year-old called Mary Shelley began writing Frankenstein, the story of a man who builds something with his own hands that turns on him. Two centuries later, you’re growing up with AI, with algorithms deciding what you see, with gene technology. The engineers ask, “Can we?” The Qur’an adds the second question: “Should we? And who is it for?” Allah never said don’t build. He said build, but build in a way that lets society flourish, not at the cost of people, and not at the cost of the akhirah, the next life.

And never give up on building. The Prophet صلى الله عليه وسلم said: “If the Final Hour is about to be established, and one of you has a sapling in his hand, let him plant it if he can.” This is reported by Imam Ahmad. Even at the end of the world: plant. Fold down a third finger.

Reason 4: To receive mercy and carry it

The fourth reason is mercy. Allah says, in Surah al-A‘raf, verse 156:

> وَرَحْمَتِي وَسِعَتْ كُلَّ شَيْءٍ

“My mercy encompasses all things.”

The Prophet صلى الله عليه وسلم told us that when Allah created creation, He wrote in a book that is with Him above the Throne: “My mercy prevails over My wrath.” This is in Sahih al-Bukhari and Sahih Muslim.

And once, some prisoners were brought to the Prophet صلى الله عليه وسلم, and among them was a woman, frantically searching for her baby. When she found him, she pressed him to her chest. The Prophet صلى الله عليه وسلم asked his companions, “Do you think this woman would throw her child into the fire?” They said, “No, by Allah.” He said, “Allah is more merciful to His servants than this woman is to her child.” This is in Sahih al-Bukhari and Sahih Muslim.

So if you’re carrying guilt tonight, hear this. Allah says in Surah az-Zumar, verse 53:

> قُلْ يَا عِبَادِيَ الَّذِينَ أَسْرَفُوا عَلَىٰ أَنفُسِهِمْ لَا تَقْنَطُوا مِن رَّحْمَةِ اللَّهِ

“Say: O My servants who have transgressed against themselves, do not despair of the mercy of Allah.”

And we’re not only meant to receive mercy, we’re meant to carry it. Allah describes the Prophet صلى الله عليه وسلم as a mercy to the worlds, in Surah al-Anbiya, verse 107:

> وَمَا أَرْسَلْنَاكَ إِلَّا رَحْمَةً لِّلْعَالَمِينَ

“We did not send you except as a mercy to the worlds.”

And he told us: “The merciful are shown mercy by the Most Merciful. Show mercy to those on earth, and the One above the heavens will show mercy to you.” This is reported by Abu Dawud and al-Tirmidhi. In a world of conflict and crisis, you can be the source of calm and kindness. The one who checks on the lonely kid. The one who doesn’t join the pile-on. Fold down your fourth finger.

Check-in: which one hit you hardest?

So there they are: test, worship, build, and mercy. Show up with excellence. Give all of life to Him. Be a caretaker who builds for good. And receive mercy, and carry it.

Now, show me with your fingers, one to four: which of those hit you hardest today? One, two, three, four. Good. Notice which one it was.

Part 5: Your Part — Finding Your Own Role

Point 1: You are not behind

Now comes the question I know is sitting in a lot of heads. That's the general purpose. But what about me?

Let me say out loud what some of you are thinking. "Okay, I get the big picture. But I'm seventeen, and I have no idea what I'm meant to do with my life, and everyone else seems to know." If that's you, you are not behind. Not knowing yet is a starting line, not a verdict.

And here's the good news. Allah did not create anyone for nothing. It would be unthinkable that the One who made everything with purpose, from the sea to the door handle, would make a single person without one. And He made us different, on purpose. He says in Surah al-Layl, verse 4:

> إِنَّ سَعْيَكُمْ لَشَتَّىٰ

"Indeed, your efforts are diverse."

And in Surah al-Isra, verse 84:

> قُلْ كُلٌّ يَعْمَلُ عَلَىٰ شَاكِلَتِهِ

"Say: each person acts according to his own manner and disposition."

Point 2: Everyone has a different strength

Many of us grew up thinking the only way to serve Allah is to become a scholar. Scholars are precious, and we need them. But look at how the Prophet صلى الله عليه وسلم built his community. He didn't make everyone the same. He named different strengths in his companions. Abu Bakr for his mercy. Umar for his firmness in Allah's matters. Uthman for his modesty. Ali for his judgement. Ubayy for his recitation. Mu'adh for his knowledge of halal and haram. Zayd for the law of inheritance. And Abu 'Ubaydah as the trustworthy one of this ummah, this Muslim community. May Allah be pleased with them all. This is reported by al-Tirmidhi.

When Abdullah ibn Zayd saw the adhan in a dream, the Prophet صلى الله عليه وسلم told him to teach it to Bilal, because Bilal had the more carrying voice. Khalid ibn al-Walid, a gifted military mind, was called one of the swords of Allah. And Hassan ibn Thabit was already a brilliant poet before Islam. After Islam, the Prophet صلى الله عليه وسلم gave him a role defending the message in verse, and said to him, "Reply to them, and Jibril is with you." This

is in Sahih al-Bukhari and Sahih Muslim. He didn't become a different person. He took the skill he already had, and he pointed it at Allah.

And when Abu Dharr, may Allah be pleased with him, asked for a position of authority, the Prophet صلى الله عليه وسلم answered him with love, not rejection. He said: "I see that you are weak, and I love for you what I love for myself. Do not take charge of even two people." This is in Sahih Muslim. Knowing your lane is wisdom, not failure.

Point 3: A five-step method to find your lane

So how do you find yours? Here's a step-by-step method.

Step one: Get self-aware, and try things. Don't wait for a lightning bolt. Try a club, a volunteer shift, a small project, a short course, or shadowing someone, which means following them for a day to see what their work is really like. Look for the qualities you have that the people around you don't. Ibn al-Qayyim, in his book on raising children, advises parents to watch what a child is naturally drawn to and help them develop it, rather than forcing them against their own nature. So if your parents have a plan for you, share this with them respectfully, and bring them into the process with a plan of your own, rather than an announcement.

Step two: Find your flow. Psychologists call it the flow state. It's when you're so absorbed in something that time disappears. When does that happen for you? Coding? Drawing? Explaining something to a friend? Organising an event? Training? Writing? What you're doing in that state is a strong clue to what Allah made you for. And the Prophet صلى الله عليه وسلم said:

> اعْمَلُوا فَكُلٌّ مُيَسَّرٌ لِمَا خُلِقَ لَهُ

"Work, for everyone is made ready for what he was created for." This is in Sahih al-Bukhari and Sahih Muslim. Now, that hadith was said in a conversation about destiny, and what we take from it is the encouragement that Allah makes things easy for each person towards what they were made for. So try different things. You'll find easy the things Allah created you to do. They'll just feel natural to you. Ask three people who know you well: "What do I do naturally that seems easy for me and hard for others?" One caution, though: a natural inclination is a clue, not a cage. And if you're struggling with something and forcing it, be honest with yourself about whether it's the right lane.

Step three: Sharpen it. Once you find what comes naturally, develop it. Invest time, invest money, find mentors, practise. Talent without training stays a hobby.

Step four: Aim for mastery. The Prophet صلى الله عليه وسلم said: "Allah has prescribed excellence in everything. So if you kill, kill well. If you slaughter, slaughter well. Let one of you sharpen his blade, and spare his animal suffering." This is in Sahih Muslim. Even a

butcher's craft is held to excellence. So whatever your craft is, whether it's code, cooking, coaching, editing, law, or plumbing, don't settle for "good enough", and don't abandon it halfway. Mastery is a journey, not a deadline, so start now.

Step five: Use it for the sake of Allah, and find the gap. The Prophet صلى الله عليه وسلم and his companions have passed on, but the jobs they did still exist. There are vacancies, and nobody to fill them. So look at the gaps around you, and ask: what problem can my skill solve? Here are some examples.

- If you're good with people, and you read them well, we need youth workers, counsellors and family therapists, people who can prevent the next divorce and rebuild the next struggling family.
- If you love sport and fitness, we need community gyms and boxing clubs that give young people somewhere to go and something to do.
- If you're good at explaining things, we need tutors and weekend schools.
- If you're into code, design or video, we need useful, honest tools and content, ethical tech, and better ways to learn the Qur'an.
- If you're heading into medicine, dentistry, law or accounting, we need sincere professionals who'll offer free or low-cost help to people who can't afford it.
- If you're organised, we need people who can run events, food drives and charities that actually work.
- If you're into business, we need fair enterprises that create decent jobs.
- And if you're someone who likes fixing, building and cleaning, we need cleaner neighbourhoods and masjids that work properly.

And understand this: you're not choosing between a career and your deen. When you do this with a sincere intention, your work is your worship. The Prophet صلى الله عليه وسلم said: "The most beloved of people to Allah are those who are most beneficial to people." This is reported by al-Tabarani.

Point 4: Try it now — two minutes

Now let's make this real. Grab a pen and a piece of paper, or open the notes app on your phone. I'm going to give you two minutes, in silence. Write down four things:

1. Three things you're good at, or that make you lose track of time.
2. One problem around you that bothers you.
3. Where those two things overlap.
4. The name of one person who has already done something like it.

Go.

[Two minutes of silence.]

Okay, that's time. Turn to the person next to you and share just one thing from your list. One minute. Go.

[One minute.]

I love that. Keep that piece of paper. It's the start of your map.

Part 6: Staying Power — Courage, Company and Fuel

Now let me be honest with you. This path can be scary, and there are endless distractions. So I want to give you three things that will keep you going: courage, company and fuel.

Point 1: Courage

First, courage. Allah gave Musa, alayhis-salam, a huge mission, and he was afraid. He said, in Surah ash-Shu'ara, verses 12 and 13:

> قَالَ رَبِّ إِنِّي أَخَافُ أَن يُكَذِّبُونِ ۝ وَيَضِيقُ صَدْرِي

"My Lord, I fear they will deny me, and my chest will tighten."

And Allah's answer, in Surah Ta-Ha, verse 46, was:

> لَا تَخَافَا ۖ إِنَّنِي مَعَكُمَا أَسْمَعُ وَأَرَىٰ

"Do not fear. I am with you both. I hear, and I see."

Being scared doesn't mean you're on the wrong path. It usually means it matters.

Point 2: Company

Second, company. Notice what Musa asked for next. He asked for a helper. He said, in Surah Ta-Ha, verses 29 to 32:

> وَاجْعَل لِّي وَزِيرًا مِّنْ أَهْلِي ۝ هَارُونَ أَخِي ۝ اشْدُدْ بِهِ أَزْرِي ۝ وَأَشْرِكْهُ فِي أَمْرِي

"Appoint for me a helper from my family, Harun, my brother. Strengthen my back through him, and let him share my task."

And Allah replied, in Surah al-Qasas, verse 35:

> قَالَ سَنَشُدُّ عَضُدَكَ بِأَخِيكَ

"We will strengthen your arm through your brother."

Even a prophet didn't do it alone. So don't you try. Allah says in Surah al-Kahf, verse 28:

> وَاصْبِرْ نَفْسَكَ مَعَ الَّذِينَ يَدْعُونَ رَبَّهُم بِالْغَدَاةِ وَالْعَشِيِّ يُرِيدُونَ وَجْهَهُ

“Keep yourself patient with those who call upon their Lord morning and evening, seeking His face.”

And the Prophet صلى الله عليه وسلم said: “A good companion and a bad one are like a musk-seller and a blacksmith. The musk-seller either gives you some, or you buy some, or at least you enjoy the scent. The blacksmith either burns your clothes, or you get a foul smell.” This is in Sahih al-Bukhari and Sahih Muslim. No single person fixes the problems we’ve talked about tonight. It takes a group of people with different skills and one shared goal. So find your companions, your mentors, your tribe.

Point 3: Fuel

Third, fuel. And there are four sources of it.

The first is silence. Before revelation came, solitude became dear to the Prophet صلى الله عليه وسلم, and he would retreat to the cave of Hira. A little quiet, away from the noise, is not wasted time.

The second is dhikr, which means remembering Allah. Allah says in Surah al-Ahzab, verse 41:

> يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا اذْكُرُوا اللَّهَ ذِكْرًا كَثِيرًا

“O you who believe, remember Allah often.”

And the Prophet صلى الله عليه وسلم said: “The likeness of the one who remembers his Lord and the one who doesn’t is the likeness of the living and the dead.” This is in Sahih al-Bukhari.

The third is the Qur’an, every day. One of the earliest commands given to the Prophet صلى الله عليه وسلم was to stand at night and recite the Qur’an with measured recitation. Allah says in Surah al-Muzzammil, verses 2 and 4:

> قُمِ اللَّيْلَ إِلَّا قَلِيلًا … وَرَتِّلِ الْقُرْآنَ تَرْتِيلًا

“Stand at night, except for a little… and recite the Qur’an in slow, measured recitation.”

And in the very same passage, in verse 5, Allah says He would cast upon him a heavy word:

> إِنَّا سَنُلْقِي عَلَيْكَ قَوْلًا ثَقِيلًا

“We are going to cast upon you a heavy word.”

A heavy mission needs fuel. And the Prophet صلى الله عليه وسلم said: “The most beloved deeds to Allah are the most consistent, even if they are small.” This is in Sahih al-Bukhari

and Sahih Muslim.

And the fourth is guarding your time. The Prophet صلى الله عليه وسلم said: "There are two blessings that many people are deceived about: health and free time." This is in Sahih al-Bukhari. Entertainment isn't evil. But when the whole day becomes escape, it isn't rest, it's anaesthetic. It just numbs you. And Allah reminds us, in Surah al-Munafiqun, verses 9 and 10, not to let our wealth or our children distract us from His remembrance:

> يَا أَيُّهَا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا لَا تُلْهِكُمْ أَمْوَالُكُمْ وَلَا أَوْلَادُكُمْ عَن ذِكْرِ اللَّهِ

"O you who believe, do not let your wealth or your children distract you from the remembrance of Allah."

And to give before death comes, and a person says:

> وَأَنفِقُوا مِن مَّا رَزَقْنَاكُم مِّن قَبْلِ أَن يَأْتِيَ أَحَدَكُمُ الْمَوْتُ فَيَقُولَ رَبِّ لَوْلَا أَخَّرْتَنِي إِلَىٰ أَجَلٍ قَرِيبٍ فَأَصَّدَّقَ وَأَكُن مِّنَ الصَّالِحِينَ

"My Lord, if only You would delay me for a short while, so that I could give charity and be among the righteous."

Part 7: The Plan — Your First Week and Beyond

Now here's the thing. Inspiration expires fast, but a plan survives. So here's your first week. Take a screenshot of this, or write it down.

The first seven days

Day one. Ten minutes alone, with your phone away. Call it your Hira ten. Write one honest sentence: "Why am I here?"

Day two. Walk outside for fifteen minutes. Look like a three-year-old. Ask "Why this way, and not another?" about five things you see, and say SubhanAllah for each one.

Day three. Start a tiny Qur'an habit. One page, or five ayahs with the translation, attached to something you already do, after Fajr or before bed. Small and consistent beats big and rare.

Day four. Do your flow audit. Write down the last three times you lost track of time, and ask three people what comes naturally to you.

Day five. Try one new thing. Sign up for a volunteer shift, a workshop, a class, or a shadowing day. You can't find your lane from the sofa.

Day six. Message one mentor. And here's what you can send: "Assalamu alaykum, I really admire your work in this field. I'm trying to learn how to do this. Could I ask you three

questions over a fifteen-minute call or a coffee? JazakAllahu khayran." That's it.

Day seven. Find your person. Invite one friend to do this with you, and book a weekly fifteen-minute check-in.

One phone boundary, all week

And one more thing, alongside the week. Pick one phone boundary: either no phone for the first thirty minutes after waking up, or no phone in bed. And fill that time with your morning adhkar, the daily words of remembrance, or a few ayahs.

After the first week: the next thirty days

After the first week, keep going for thirty days. Choose one skill and practise it for thirty minutes a day. Start one small service project: tutoring, a clean-up, a workshop, a community event. And once a month, hold yourself to account. Umar, may Allah be pleased with him, is reported to have said: "Hold yourselves to account before you are held to account." Ask yourself: how did I spend my time? What am I proud of? What will I change?

A note before you go

And if anything tonight stirred something heavy in you, please don't carry it alone. Talk to someone you trust, see your doctor, or reach out to a counsellor or a local helpline. Seeking help and treatment is encouraged in our tradition.

Closing: The Day Everyone Wakes Up

Let me finish where we started: with the zombies, the sheep and the NPC. There is a day when everyone wakes up. Allah describes it in Surah Qaf, verse 22:

> لَّقَدْ كُنتَ فِي غَفْلَةٍ مِّنْ هَٰذَا فَكَشَفْنَا عَنكَ غِطَاءَكَ فَبَصَرُكَ الْيَوْمَ حَدِيدٌ

"You were heedless of this, so We have removed your covering, and today your sight is sharp."

On that day, we will see clearly that all of this had a purpose, and an ending. The only question is whether we wake up then, or now, while we can still act on it. The day will come when the answer to "What was my life for?" is obvious to everyone. What we won't have then is time. We have it now.

And here is this whole session in three short verses. Allah says, in Surah al-'Asr:

> وَالْعَصْرِ ۝ إِنَّ الْإِنسَانَ لَفِي خُسْرٍ ۝ إِلَّا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا وَعَمِلُوا الصَّالِحَاتِ وَتَوَاصَوْا بِالْحَقِّ وَتَوَاصَوْا بِالصَّبْرِ

"By time. Indeed, mankind is in loss, except those who believe, do righteous deeds, advise

one another to the truth, and advise one another to patience.”

Four ingredients. Know your why: that’s belief. Do the work: that’s righteous deeds. Remind each other of the truth: that’s the third. And help each other keep going: that’s patience.

So don’t leave tonight asking, “Did I enjoy that?” Leave asking, “What’s the first thing I’m doing tomorrow?”

The final dua

Let’s make dua together. Raise your hands.

> رَبِّ زِدْنِي عِلْمًا

“My Lord, increase me in knowledge.”

> يَا مُقَلِّبَ الْقُلُوبِ ثَبِّتْ قَلْبِي عَلَىٰ دِينِكَ

“O Turner of hearts, make my heart firm upon Your religion.”

Ya Allah, show each one of us our purpose. Give us the skill to serve You with, the courage to start, and the companions to keep us going. Wake us up now, while it still counts. Ameen.

Whatever I said that was right is from Allah alone. Whatever was wrong is from me and from Shaytan, and I ask Allah’s forgiveness.

> سُبْحَانَكَ اللَّهُمَّ وَبِحَمْدِكَ، أَشْهَدُ أَنْ لَا إِلَٰهَ إِلَّا أَنْتَ، أَسْتَغْفِرُكَ وَأَتُوبُ إِلَيْكَ

“Glory and praise be to You, O Allah. I bear witness that there is no god but You. I seek Your forgiveness and turn to You in repentance.”

Assalamu alaykum wa rahmatullahi wa barakatuh.